

faster?" Ordinarily, this would have elicited a reaction that would rise through the YouTube ranks like nothing before it. However, the response was even stranger: "Open source is interesting. Apple has embraced WebKit and we may look at that, but we will continue to build extensions for IE 8."

Before you head out into the streets cheering, note that last bit: "build extensions for IE 8." Which means that even if IE 8 uses WebKit, Microsoft will continue to make IE-specific features, which means that it won't end the messy era of IE-specific code. Soon after, Ballmer confirmed that Microsoft hasn't suddenly gone soft — the company will stick to its current Trident rendering engine, because "there will continue to be a lot of proprietary innovation by us, and other people, inside the browser itself."

Had Microsoft decided to the WebKit way, however, there would have been a lot to look forward to. Firstly, with the growing number of Macs, Web developers need to make sure that their applications work with Safari, which uses WebKit. Secondly, and more importantly, a WebKit-powered IE on Windows Mobile devices wouldn't be nearly as awful. Android phones use WebKit as well, so a site designed for WebKit will work well with IE and Chrome on your PC, Safari on your Mac, IE on your Windows Mobile phone, and the browser on your Android phone. Finally, the WebKit-powered Safari 4 beta is the only browser engine to pass the ACID 3 test so far. The WebKit Way would have brought us a Web that we've all dreamed of: one that is standards compliant, and runs everywhere.

And, of course, it had to be Microsoft who ruined it.

YOUR OWN LITTLE MELTDOWN

Personal Nuclear Reactors

In his Foundation series, Isaac Asimov reveals his love for tiny nuclear reactors — they power everything, from guns to personal shields to costume jewellery. In the present, however, we see two huge towers and an accident waiting to happen. Somewhere in between, you'll find the upcoming Hyperion Hybride Reactor.

Built by the Arizona-based Hyperion, the Hybride reactor is about the size of a Jacuzzi, is completely sealed, is practically maintenance-free, has no moving parts, and will power up to 20,000 homes. Much though we like the picture of a glowy, throbbing reactor in the middle of our localities, this is not to be. The Hybride will be buried underground, and will need to be dug up every seven years or so for refuelling.

The company has already received a hundred orders from various industries and developing countries, and there's already a six-year waiting list. And all this for something that's still five years away.

Toshiba is working on its own miniature nuclear reactor as well — the 4S (super-safe, small and simple), which will be ready for its first field test in 2012. It'll be smaller than the Hybride, and will last 30-40 years without refuelling.

The possibilities for something like this in India are wonderful: no longer will our small cities and villages have to suffer power outages so that the big cities keep ticking. They could become self-contained units, independent of the power grid. In countries worse off than ours, these reactors could go where no power source has ever gone before. Most importantly, it'll all be clean power — right now, nuclear power has almost no carbon footprint. There is, however, the matter of getting organisations like Greenpeace to stop ruining its good name.



CRACK A BIG :-)

Emotion And IM

As writers, we've loathed what instant messaging has done to people. While we meticulously craft our sentences and use whole words, there's usually an idiot at the other end *tryn 2 tlk lk ths*. Of course, that doesn't mean we don't love the medium.

There are many who believe that IM throws sand in the face of the statement that you lose about 85 per cent of communication when you're not face-to-face. That idea would make sense when we're talking about letters, but this is instant messaging we're talking about. IM isn't writing, it's speaking. In text. And now, it's been proved that IM is just as successful at communicating emotion as regular interaction.

Jeffery Hancock at Cornell University asked 44 volunteers to chat with a partner for about 20 minutes, find out more about each other and discuss their woes. Before the chat, one partner from each pair was shown either a particularly depressing scene from *Sophie's Choice*, or a boring video of a small talk. After the chat, the participants were asked to comment on their partners' mood, and surprisingly enough, all of them were dead accurate. Even more surprising, people who were paired with partners who had watched *Sophie's Choice* actually felt sadder than they did before the chat.

Of course, there will be many who disagree — face-to-face is the only way, they'll say. And that's